

Practice-Realization and Shikantaza

1. Practice and realization

Dogen's mature rhetoric is often summarized as 'practice-realization': practice is not a deficient activity undertaken by an unenlightened subject to acquire a separate enlightened result. The two are nondual. This formulation protects against attainment-seeking, but it immediately raises a question: if practice is realization, why distinguish skilled from unskilled practice, teacher from beginner, or discipline from distraction?

2. Shikantaza

'Just sitting' is deceptively simple English. It does not mean 'merely sit however you like.' In Soto contexts it is embedded in posture, schedule, teacher instruction, precepts, monastery rules, and a doctrinal account of non-seeking. The word 'just' removes an extra acquisitive project; it does not remove form.

3. Bendōwa and total exertion

In texts such as Bendowa, zazen is presented not as one sectarian technique among many but as the authentic gate of practice. Elsewhere Dogen describes each activity as total exertion. The philosophical pressure is to think action without a self standing outside it and owning it. 'Just sitting' can therefore be read as a model of action without a surplus controller.

4. The beginner paradox

Suppose realization is fully present in practice. A beginner's distracted sitting is then both genuinely practice-realization and obviously not equivalent to mature conduct. One response distinguishes ontological completeness from functional expression: nothing needs to be added to Buddha-nature, but habits of grasping still condition how activity unfolds. Training is not manufacturing completeness; it is the ongoing form in which completeness is expressed.

5. No gaining idea

Modern Soto teaching often warns against a 'gaining idea.' That is not a ban on intention. One must still arrive, sit, follow forms, and correct posture. The target is the structure in which the present is treated only as an instrument for possessing a future state. A practice can be purposive without being acquisitive.

6. Ritual reading of zazen

Scholars of Zen ritual have argued that zazen itself can be understood as ritual: a formalized, embodied, repeated performance that enacts a cosmological and institutional claim. Calling zazen ritual does not trivialize it. It prevents 'meditation' from being falsely isolated as private psychology while everything around it is dismissed as cultural packaging.

7. Objection from circularity

Argument: 'zazen is realization because proper zazen is enlightened activity' can become circular if 'proper' is defined only as whatever counts as realization. To avoid circularity, specify observable and textual criteria: non-acquisitive orientation, bodily form, integration with precepts and communal discipline, and the tradition's accounts of reactivity and attachment.

8. Question

Is shikantaza a method? If 'method' means a procedure for causing a later result, Dogen resists the term. If it means a learnable, norm-governed form of practice, refusing the term can obscure what monasteries plainly teach. A careful answer should state which sense of method it accepts or rejects.

1. Goals

A practice-realization account rejects two claims: (a) zazen is only an instrument whose value lies in causing a later enlightenment-state; (b) if enlightenment is not produced by zazen, disciplined practice is dispensable. The aim is to explain how practice can be fully expressive of awakening without making every instance of sitting equally skillful or every practitioner equally realized.

2. Three cases

Case 1: Instrument. A student sits solely because a teacher promises a dramatic state after 10,000 hours. If the state could be obtained by a pill, the sitting would have no remaining value. Case 2: Display. A student assumes realization is already complete and treats any posture or conduct as its expression. Case 3: Enactment. A student treats prescribed sitting as the activity in which non-grasping is practiced now, without turning the present into currency for a later possession. The third best fits practice-realization but requires further explanation.

3. Three options

Option A: only the future result matters. Problem: this reinstates the means/end dualism Dōgen explicitly attacks. Option B: no result and no norm matter. Problem: this cannot distinguish zazen from distraction or cruelty. Option C: the practice is intrinsically norm-governed and complete as practice while transformations in stability, conduct, and understanding can still occur over time. Option C is the most promising, but it must explain what 'complete' contributes if development remains possible.

4. What matters for practice?

The relevant continuity may not be continuity of special experiences. A practitioner can have no dramatic breakthrough and still develop less acquisitive, less self-centered activity; another can report an intense experience and remain rigid. This motivates a shift from event ownership to patterns of enactment. Dōgen's language of total exertion and dropping body-mind can be read as resisting the idea that an isolated inner episode is the unit by which realization should be measured.

5. Fission

Suppose two communities inherit the same Dōgen texts. Community A preserves precise zazen forms but explains them as a technique for producing kenshō. Community B alters some forms but interprets practice as non-instrumental realization. Which is more continuous with practice-realization? The case forces a choice among formal, doctrinal, and institutional criteria. There may be no fact of the matter until the sense of continuity is fixed.

6. Refining the account

A refined account can distinguish constitutive and developmental claims. Constitutive: when zazen is performed as non-acquisitive, embodied practice, realization is not located elsewhere as a separate product. Developmental: the practitioner's capacity to sustain and express this mode across situations can change. The distinction allows 'practice is realization' and 'practice matures' to coexist without turning one into metaphor.

7. Upshots

(a) A spectacular experience is neither necessary nor sufficient for the practice-realization relation as described here. (b) The absence of an acquisition goal does not eliminate correction, discipline, or learning. (c) Teacher authority cannot be justified merely by claiming private experience; it has to be situated in practices of recognition. (d) A modern reduction of shikantaza to stress reduction changes the end structure even if the posture remains visually similar.

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